LUKMAAN IAS
A LEADING INSTITUTE FOR IAS EXAMINATION

ISSUE - 2

UPSC CSE | PERSONALITY TEST (INTERVIEW)

Current Issues for the Interview

Probable Questions with View-Based Answers

OCTOBER 2026

National Affairs | Society & Security | Economic Affairs | Ecology | International Relations | Science & Tech

26 board questions • Follow-up chains • DAF hooks • Month at a glance • Practice rubric

Inside This Issue

•	**Month at a Glance & Refresh Box**	Page 3
01	**National Affairs** GS-II: Polity & Governance	Q1–Q4
02	**Society & Internal Security** GS-I: Society | GS-II: Social Justice | GS-III: Internal Security	Q5–Q8
03	**Economic Affairs** GS-III: Indian Economy	Q9–Q13
04	**Ecology & Environment** GS-III: Environment & Disaster Management	Q14–Q17
05	**International Relations** GS-II: International Relations	Q18–Q22
06	**Science & Technology** GS-III: Science & Technology, Cyber Security	Q23–Q26
•	**Rapid-fire Board Traps**	10 traps
•	**Practice Lab & Self-Evaluation Rubric**	10 questions

How to Use This Issue

This issue carries **26 probable board questions** on the issue-based developments of **October 2026** across six areas. Each answer can be spoken in 60–90 seconds. Event-only items such as awards, sports and important days are left out; every question here asks for your opinion.

Facts are **as on 31 October 2026**. October data released in early November (GST collections) is marked **UPDATE (NOV)**.

EVERY ANSWER IN THIS ISSUE HAS SEVEN PARTS	
My View	Your position in one sentence. Say it first.
Reasoning	Two reasons, one hard fact. Not five numbers.
Counterpoint I Accept	The strongest argument against you, conceded honestly.
Way Forward	What you would do, ideally as an administrator.
Must-Know	Two or three facts (Article, Act, judgment, number) that boards like to check.
Follow-up Chain	How a board member is likely to press you, probe by probe, with crisp replies.
DAF Hooks	How the topic may be linked to your optional, graduation or home state.

ANSWER SPINE: View → Two reasons + one fact → Counterpoint I accept → Way forward (60–90 seconds)

October 2026 at a Glance

Read this page in the waiting room. Each line is a hook the board can use to open a conversation.

1 Oct	AFSPA extended in Manipur for six months	SOCIETY
3 Oct	Split verdict in SC on CEC appointment law	NATIONAL
5 Oct	India–Canada CEPA: fifth round begins	IR
7 Oct	RBI raises repo to 5.50%; India–EFTA Prosperity Summit	ECONOMY
8 Oct	Vaishnaw: AI consultation paper soon; pre-COP31 in Fiji	S&T
10 Oct	CJP protest; Delhi lockdown; RBI dollar window for oil firms	NATIONAL
12 Oct	September CPI 5.54%, a 23-month high	ECONOMY
19–20 Oct	SCO Heads of Government meeting, Dushanbe	IR
20 Oct	SC: conversion does not confer BC status; India–NZ FTA in force	SOCIETY
21 Oct	SBI discloses data breach	S&T
22 Oct	Modi–Tusk talks; India–Poland aim to double trade by 2030	IR
23 Oct	SC orders national CSAM hash database	SOCIETY
28 Oct	Cyclone Arnab hits Andhra coast; stubble study released	ECOLOGY
30 Oct	Rabi sowing 46% below last year	ECONOMY
1 Nov	UPDATE: October GST at ₹2.31 lakh crore (+22.9%)	ECONOMY

Refresh Before Your Interview

These figures move fast. Values are as on 31 October 2026 (October updates noted). Write the latest value in the last column on the eve of your interview.

Indicator	As on this issue	Latest (fill in)
CPI inflation	5.54% (Sept); Oct due 12 Nov	
RBI repo rate	5.50% (since 7 Oct)	
Rupee vs dollar	~96.8 (Oct); record 96.96	
Strait of Hormuz	Effectively closed (late Oct)	
Rabi sown area	37.56 lakh ha (30 Oct)	
India–EU FTA	Signing planned Dec 2026	
India–US trade deal	First tranche pending	
CEC Act challenge	Referred to CJI after split	
Delimitation Bill, 2026	On hold	
Gaganyaan G1 (uncrewed)	Targeted within 2026	

SECTION 01

National Affairs

GS-II: Polity & Governance

CONTEXT CAPSULE The Cockroach Janta Party's campaign against the CEC and the Special Intensive Revision peaked on 10 October: Delhi police detained about 2,000–2,500 people, shut dozens of metro stations, sealed Jantar Mantar and suspended mobile internet in central Delhi. The Supreme Court called the transport bans "overreaching". On 3 October a two-judge bench split on the 2023 law on appointing Election Commissioners, and the matter went to the CJI. The Delimitation Bill, 2026 (Lok Sabha 543 → 850) stays on hold amid a record delay in proroguing Parliament.

IF YOUR DAF SAYS...	PROBABLE QUESTION	YOUR ANGLE
Public Administration optional	*"Is policing of protests a test of 'responsive administration'?"*	Link to Riggs' prismatic society and New Public Service: dialogue, designated spaces and proportionate force.
Law / Political Science graduate	*"Why does a split verdict go to a larger bench?"*	Art. 145(3): a substantial question of constitutional interpretation needs at least five judges.
Delhi / NCR resident	*"You live in Delhi; was the metro shutdown justified?"*	Answer as a citizen and an administrator: lakhs of commuters bore the cost; regulate, don't shut.
Tamil Nadu / Kerala / South	*"Will an 850-seat Lok Sabha be fair to your state?"*	Seats rise 129 → 195; share stays ~23.8%. Fairness also needs Rajya Sabha and fiscal federalism.

Q1 To stop a protest against the Chief Election Commissioner, Delhi saw metro closures, internet suspension and about 2,000 detentions. Was this justified?

MY VIEW: Public order was a legitimate concern, but the response was disproportionate. Shutting a city to stop a protest treats every citizen as a suspect.

The Supreme Court itself found the metro and train bans "overreaching" and asked for regulated services and identified protest sites. Blanket preventive detention and internet suspension hurt lakhs of commuters, workers and students who had nothing to do with the protest.

COUNTERPOINT I ACCEPT Police act on intelligence about crowd size and possible violence, and a protest at the heart of the capital near Parliament carries real security risk. Hindsight is easy.

WAY FORWARD Designated protest sites with capacity limits, targeted detention of known troublemakers only, regulated (not suspended) transport, and dialogue channels with organisers before the date.

MUST-KNOW Anuradha Bhasin v. UoI (2020): internet suspension must be necessary, proportionate, temporary and reviewed. Mazdoor Kisan Shakti Sangathan v. UoI (2018): protests at Jantar Mantar allowed with regulation, not a blanket ban. M A Baby v. UoI (Oct 2026): metro/train bans "overreaching"; compliance report in 4 days.

FOLLOW-UP CHAIN

P1	*"As Commissioner of Police, what would you have done?"* → Allow the protest at Jantar Mantar with a cap on numbers, deploy heavily around Parliament, and keep metro running with crowd control at nearby stations.
P2	*"What if intelligence warned of violence?"* → Act on specific individuals and specific places. Preventive action must be targeted, recorded and reviewable.
P3	*"Isn't internet suspension needed to stop rumours?"* → Only as a last resort, for the shortest time and smallest area, with the order published, as Anuradha Bhasin requires.

Q2 The Supreme Court delivered a split verdict on the law for appointing Election Commissioners. Should a Constitution Bench now decide it?

MY VIEW: Yes. The independence of the body that conducts our elections is a substantial constitutional question, and it needs an authoritative answer quickly.

One judge refused to refer the challenge to a larger bench; the other favoured a Constitution Bench. The papers are now with the CJI. Meanwhile, every big decision of the Commission, including the SIR, is being read through the lens of how its members were appointed.

COUNTERPOINT I ACCEPT	Parliament legislated exactly as Anoop Baranwal invited it to. Courts redesigning the appointment process may look like judicial overreach into a legislative choice.
WAY FORWARD	List the reference early and decide it within months. The government could also defuse the debate by voluntarily adding a neutral member to the panel.

MUST-KNOW Art. 145(3): substantial questions of constitutional interpretation need at least five judges. Anoop Baranwal v. UoI (2023): PM, LoP and CJI panel until Parliament makes a law. CEC and Other ECs Act, 2023: PM, LoP and a Union Cabinet minister. Dr. Jaya Thakur v. UoI split reported 3 Oct 2026.

FOLLOW-UP CHAIN

P1	*"Isn't the executive majority on the panel enough for efficiency?"* → Efficiency is not the test for an umpire; perceived neutrality is.
P2	*"Who should replace the CJI if not on the panel?"* → Any neutral authority, such as the Speaker or a retired judge; the principle is that no single side controls the outcome.
P3	*"Is the delay itself harmful?"* → Yes. An unresolved challenge keeps doubt alive through every election in between.

Q3 After the CJI declined to meet opposition leaders, a contempt petition was filed against a journalist and an MP for criticising him. Where is the line between criticism of the judiciary and contempt?

MY VIEW: Criticism of judgments, and even of a judge's conduct, is legitimate in a democracy. Contempt should be reserved for attacks that actually obstruct justice.

The CJI was right not to meet political leaders on a matter pending before the Court; that protects judicial independence. But the institution's strength lies in its reasoning, not in silencing critics. Courts are respected more when they are seen as thick-skinned.

COUNTERPOINT I ACCEPT Judges cannot answer back in public. Imputing motives to a CJI, especially in a charged political moment, can erode public faith in courts that have no army or purse.

WAY FORWARD Use contempt sparingly, prefer an apology route (as happened here), and let truth and public interest be a full defence. Communicate decisions clearly so that misinformation has less room.

MUST-KNOW Arts. 129 and 215: Supreme Court and High Courts as courts of record with contempt powers. Contempt of Courts Act, 1971: truth in public interest a defence since the 2006 amendment (S. 13). Re: Prashant Bhushan (2020): ₹1 fine for tweets on the judiciary.

FOLLOW-UP CHAIN

P1 *"Was the CJI right not to meet the INDIA bloc?"*
→ Yes. Allegations of electoral discrepancy were pending before the Court; a meeting would have compromised neutrality.

P2 *"Should 'scandalising the court' be abolished, as in the UK (2013)?"*
→ It deserves serious review; a narrower definition would protect both courts and free speech.

P3 *"Is social media making judges more vulnerable?"*
→ Yes, which is why courts should explain more and punish less.

Q4 The Delimitation Bill proposes an 850-seat Lok Sabha but is on hold, and Parliament's prorogation has been delayed for a record period. Should the Lok Sabha be expanded?

MY VIEW: Yes in principle, because each MP now represents over 25 lakh people. But it must come through federal consensus and Census data, not a rushed session.

Seats have been frozen on the 1971 population since 1976. Expansion lets northern states gain seats without the south losing any; the Home Minister said southern seats would rise from 129 to 195 and their share would stay at about 23.8%.

COUNTERPOINT I ACCEPT A bigger House does not automatically mean better debate; sittings have fallen, and more members may mean even less speaking time. Delaying prorogation to keep a session "alive" also weakens parliamentary convention.

WAY FORWARD Delimitation after Census data, an all-party consensus on a formula that does not penalise states for population control, and stronger committees so that a larger House still deliberates.

MUST-KNOW Arts. 81–82; 42nd Amendment (1976) froze seats on 1971 Census; 84th Amendment (2001) extended the freeze to the first Census after 2026. Delimitation Bill, 2026 introduced 16 April 2026: 543 → 850 seats (815 states, 35 UTs). Art. 85: no more than six months between two sessions.

FOLLOW-UP CHAIN

P1 *"Why not just link seats strictly to population?"*
→ That rewards states that failed at population control; a weighted formula is fairer.

P2 *"Is the delay in prorogation unconstitutional?"*
→ Not unconstitutional, but unconventional. Conventions keep the executive accountable to Parliament.

P3 *"Should women's reservation wait for this?"*
→ No. Women's reservation can be implemented on existing seats by rotation.

LUKMAAN IAS • OPTIONAL • NOVEMBER BATCH 2026
Public Administration Crash Course
Offline only • 5:30 PM – 8:00 PM, Monday to Friday
Starts 16 Nov 2026

30 classes, 5 days a week
PYQ-to-NYQ approach with PYQ brainstorming & discussion
Mind-maps on recurring themes
Recent recommendations, reports and developments added
Soft copies: new facts & examples
Hard copy: a book on contemporary & current developments

Fee **₹18,000** • Ex-PA YLT / Test Series students ₹16,000 • Ex-PA Foundation students ₹13,000
+91 96540 34293
lukmaanias.com

SECTION 02

Society & Internal Security

GS-I: Society | GS-II: Social Justice | GS-III: Internal Security

CONTEXT CAPSULE Manipur's Census was deferred on 31 August after demands for an NRC first; AFSPA was extended for six months from 1 October, and fresh violence on 18–20 October killed four. The Supreme Court held on 20 October that conversion to Islam does not by itself confer Backward Class Muslim status, directed a national database to block child sexual abuse material on 23 October, and quashed an NSA detention from the Sambhal violence that rested only on an alleged forced confession.

IF YOUR DAF SAYS...	PROBABLE QUESTION	YOUR ANGLE
Sociology / Anthropology optional	*"Does caste survive religious conversion?"*	Yes, socially; cite studies on Dalit Christians and Pasmanda Muslims. The law is yet to catch up.
Northeast / Manipur background	*"Can an NRC bring peace to Manipur?"*	It can address migration fears, but peace needs political dialogue and the return of the displaced first.
Psychology / Social Work	*"How should we protect children online?"*	Platform duty of care, school-level digital safety, and survivor-centric POCSO processes.
Law graduate	*"Is preventive detention compatible with liberty?"*	Art. 22 permits it, but courts read it strictly; mention A.K. Roy (1982) and advisory boards.

Q5 Manipur's Census has been deferred because groups want an NRC first. Should the Census wait for an NRC?

MY VIEW: No. The Census counts residents, not citizens. Holding it hostage to an NRC denies Manipur the data it needs for welfare and planning.

The demand reflects real anxiety about migration from Myanmar, and the Assembly endorsed it on 2 September. But an NRC in a state where thousands are still displaced and communities are physically separated would be contested from day one, as Assam's experience shows.

COUNTERPOINT I ACCEPT Counting during conflict, with people in relief camps and buffer zones, may itself be unreliable and could be used to settle territorial claims.

WAY FORWARD A special enumeration in relief camps, a separate time-bound and court-monitored verification of recent migrants, tighter border management, and a political dialogue that puts return of the displaced first.

MUST-KNOW Census in Manipur deferred on 31 August 2026; Assembly resolution for NRC before Census on 2 September. AFSPA, 1958 extended in Manipur for six months from 1 October 2026 (13 police stations excluded). Free Movement Regime with Myanmar curtailed in 2024.

FOLLOW-UP CHAIN

P1 *"Is AFSPA still needed after three years?"*
→ In the hill districts with armed groups, yes for now; it should be reviewed area by area, not renewed by habit.

P2 *"Why did Assam's NRC fail to satisfy anyone?"*
→ Paper-heavy proof, a huge exclusion list and no clear plan for those excluded.

P3 *"As DC of a buffer-zone district, your priority?"*
→ Safety of both communities, functioning schools and health centres, and a trusted grievance channel.

Q6 The Supreme Court held that converting to Islam does not automatically entitle a person to Backward Class Muslim reservation. Do you agree?

MY VIEW: Yes. Reservation is for social backwardness, a lived condition, not a label that can be acquired by conversion.

If conversion alone conferred benefits, reservation could be gamed and genuinely backward members of the community would lose out. The judgment also brings back the larger, unresolved question: Dalits who convert to Christianity or Islam still face caste discrimination but are excluded from SC status.

COUNTERPOINT I ACCEPT Converts often carry their caste disadvantage with them; denying them benefits can punish a constitutionally protected choice of faith.

WAY FORWARD Decide each claim on evidence of backwardness, and settle the SC-status question for Dalit converts on the basis of the Balakrishnan Commission's findings and empirical data.

MUST-KNOW Constitution (SC) Order, 1950, para 3: SC status only for Hindus, Sikhs (1956) and Buddhists (1990). Justice K.G. Balakrishnan Commission (2022) examining SC status for Dalit converts. State v. Sameer Ahamed N. (reported 20 Oct 2026); Art. 16(4).

FOLLOW-UP CHAIN

P1 *"Doesn't this discourage conversion?"*
→ No. It only says benefits follow backwardness, not religion.

P2 *"Should Dalit Christians get SC status?"*
→ If data shows untouchability-based disadvantage persists, yes; the decision should rest on evidence.

P3 *"Is a religion-neutral reservation possible?"*
→ Yes, through backwardness-based criteria, as the OBC lists already partly do.

Q7 The Supreme Court has ordered a national database to block child sexual abuse material and said internet access is a fundamental right. Can child safety and digital freedom go together?

MY VIEW: Yes. A safe internet is a precondition for children to enjoy the right to access it.

The Court asked for a National Hash and URL database and time-bound reporting by platforms. Hash-matching blocks known abuse images without reading private messages, and it is already used worldwide. Recognising access as a right also means the state cannot use child safety as an excuse for broad censorship.

COUNTERPOINT I ACCEPT Pressure to scan everything can push platforms towards weakening encryption, and small Indian platforms may struggle with compliance costs.

WAY FORWARD A national centre like the US NCMEC, hash-matching on public and cloud content, fast-track POCSO courts, and digital-safety education in schools.

MUST-KNOW Just Rights for Children Alliance v. S. Harish (2024): viewing or storing CSAM is an offence under POCSO; Court suggested the term "CSEAM". Directions of 23 Oct 2026: National Hash & URL List Database; next listed 10 December 2026. POCSO Act, 2012; IT Act, 2000 Sec. 67B.

FOLLOW-UP CHAIN

P1	*"Should end-to-end encryption be broken to catch offenders?"* → No. Encryption protects children too; use metadata, reports and hash-matching on unencrypted layers.
P2	*"Who should be liable, platform or uploader?"* → The uploader criminally; the platform if it ignores reporting and takedown duties.
P3	*"As SP, what would you do on such a complaint?"* → Preserve evidence, report to the national portal, protect the child's identity, and file under POCSO within hours.

Q8 The Supreme Court quashed an NSA detention that rested only on a confession allegedly obtained by torture, and imposed ₹10 lakh costs on the state. Should preventive detention laws be reformed?

MY VIEW: Preventive detention has a place in national security, but its misuse as a substitute for ordinary criminal law needs stronger safeguards.

Here the accused already had bail in every FIR. Detaining him anyway, on a confession the state did not deny was coerced, turns preventive detention into punishment without trial. Costs on the state send the right signal of accountability.

COUNTERPOINT I ACCEPT Some threats, like organised communal violence or terror networks, move faster than courts; police need a tool to act before harm occurs.

WAY FORWARD Independent advisory boards with judicial members, time limits that are actually enforced, publication of detention data, and personal accountability of officers for mala fide orders.

MUST-KNOW Art. 22(3)–(7): preventive detention with advisory board review; the 44th Amendment's change to Art. 22 was never notified (A.K. Roy, 1982). National Security Act, 1980: maximum 12 months; reference to an advisory board within 3 weeks. Bench: Justices Dipankar Datta and Sheel Nagu (Oct 2026).

FOLLOW-UP CHAIN	
P1	*"Doesn't bail in all FIRs prove the system works?"* → It shows ordinary law was working, which is exactly why preventive detention was unjustified.
P2	*"As DM, would you ever sign an NSA order?"* → Only on fresh, specific material showing imminent threat to public order, and never to get around bail.
P3	*"Should costs be recovered from the officer?"* → Where mala fides is proved, yes; accountability must be personal, not only institutional.

SECTION 03

Economic Affairs

GS-III: Indian Economy

CONTEXT CAPSULE Retail inflation rose to a 23-month high of 5.54% in September, with food at 7.74% and onions up 108%. The RBI raised the repo rate to 5.50% on 7 October and, on 10 October, opened a direct dollar window for oil companies as the rupee neared its record low. Rabi sowing was 46% lower than last year by 30 October. UPDATE (NOV): October GST collections rose 22.9% to ₹2.31 lakh crore, the second-highest ever. The India–EU FTA is set to be signed in December.

IF YOUR DAF SAYS...	PROBABLE QUESTION	YOUR ANGLE
Economics graduate / optional	*"Why should a central bank care about onion prices?"*	Food has a large CPI weight and drives household inflation expectations, which feed wages.
Farmer family / rural district	*"Why is rabi sowing so late in your area?"*	Prepare one local fact: soil moisture, canal water or input prices.
Commerce / CA / management	*"Is record GST a sign of strong demand?"*	Partly; imports and a weak rupee inflate IGST. Look at domestic GST growth (15.8%).
Public Administration optional	*"Is GST a model of cooperative federalism?"*	The GST Council (Art. 279A) is a unique shared institution, though states lost fiscal autonomy.

Q9 Retail inflation is at a 23-month high and onion prices have doubled. Should the government curb exports and impose stock limits?

MY VIEW: Use targeted supply tools, but avoid blanket export bans. They punish farmers for a weather shock they did not cause.

Food inflation at 7.74% hurts the poor most, and rural inflation (6.08%) is higher than urban. But past onion export bans damaged India's reputation as a reliable supplier and cut farmers' incomes just when prices finally rewarded them.

COUNTERPOINT I ACCEPT When food inflation threatens to breach the 6% upper band, households cannot wait for markets to adjust; quick, visible action also anchors expectations.

WAY FORWARD Release buffer stocks through open-market sales, use the Price Stabilisation Fund, time-bound stock limits on traders, and invest in cold storage and onion dehydration capacity.

MUST-KNOW CPI inflation, Sept 2026: 5.54% (Aug 4.83%); food 7.74%; onion +108%. RBI target: 4% ± 2%; October CPI due 12 November. Essential Commodities Act, 1955 (stock limits); Price Stabilisation Fund (2014–15).

FOLLOW-UP CHAIN

P1 *"Why do onion prices swing so wildly every year?"*
→ Few states grow most of it, storage is poor, and small supply shifts cause large price moves.

P2 *"Should the RBI raise rates again for food inflation?"*
→ Rates cannot grow onions; they matter only if food inflation spreads into wages and core prices.

P3 *"One long-term fix?"*
→ Scientific storage near farms, so that the harvest glut is not followed by a lean-season spike.

Q10 With the rupee near its record low, the RBI now sells dollars directly to oil companies and has curbed currency derivatives. Is defending the rupee wise?

MY VIEW: Smoothing volatility is wise; defending a fixed level is not. The oil-company window is a sensible, targeted step.

Oil marketing companies' daily dollar demand is large and lumpy, and taking it off the spot market reduces panic. Curbing speculative derivative positions also helps. But reserves are finite, and an overvalued rupee hurts exporters.

COUNTERPOINT I ACCEPT Direct supply to oil companies drains reserves steadily, and tighter derivative rules may make it harder for genuine businesses to hedge.

WAY FORWARD Let the rupee adjust gradually, keep the window temporary, attract stable inflows (bonds, FDI) and reduce the oil import bill structurally.

MUST-KNOW 10 Oct 2026: dollar window for IOC, HPCL, BPCL from 12 Oct; exchange-traded rupee derivative limit cut from $100 mn to $5 mn. Rupee ~96.78/$ (9 Oct); record low 96.96 (May 2026). Precedent: RBI swap window for oil companies, August 2013.

FOLLOW-UP CHAIN

P1 *"Is a weak rupee always bad?"*
→ No. It helps exporters and discourages imports; the problem is volatility, not the level.

P2 *"Should India have a target exchange rate?"*
→ No. Under inflation targeting, the rupee must be market-determined with intervention only for volatility.

P3 *"What would you tell an exporter worried about hedging?"*
→ Genuine hedges are still allowed; the curbs target speculative and duplicate positions.

Q11 Rabi sowing is down 46% from last year, and wheat sowing has barely begun. Is India's food security at risk?

MY VIEW: Not yet a crisis, but a serious warning. Early-season data exaggerates the gap, yet soil moisture and reservoir levels are genuinely low.

A weak monsoon has left low soil moisture and below-normal reservoirs in key wheat states. The government has set a lower foodgrain target and is pushing pulses, oilseeds and millets. Buffer stocks protect consumers; farmers in rainfed areas carry the real risk.

COUNTERPOINT I ACCEPT Sowing may catch up in November as temperatures fall, and October figures every year are a small fraction of the final rabi area.

WAY FORWARD Water-budget-based district crop plans, heat-tolerant seed, quick drought declarations so relief flows, and assured procurement for pulses so that farmers can switch crops.

MUST-KNOW Rabi area 37.56 lakh ha by 30 Oct 2026 vs 69.02 lakh ha a year ago; wheat −94%. Rabi target 177.72 MT; 2026–27 foodgrain target 373.93 MT. Khet Bachao Abhiyan: 22 Oct–30 Nov 2026; Maharashtra declared 265 of 358 talukas drought-hit.

FOLLOW-UP CHAIN

P1 *"Should India import wheat?"*
→ Only if stocks fall below buffer norms; announcing imports too early depresses farm prices.

P2 *"Why won't farmers grow pulses?"*
→ Price and procurement uncertainty; assured purchase at MSP changes behaviour quickly.

P3 *"As Collector, your rabi plan?"*
→ Soil-moisture mapping, seed and fertiliser at village level, and MGNREGA works for farm ponds.

Q12 October GST collections rose 23% to the second-highest level ever, despite last year's rate cuts. Does this prove that lower tax rates raise revenue?

MY VIEW: Partly. Simpler, lower rates improved compliance and consumption, but one month's surge also reflects imports and a weaker rupee.

GST on imports rose 42%, partly because a weaker rupee raises the rupee value of imports and festive stocking was front-loaded. Domestic collections grew a healthier but smaller 15.8%. The real test is whether growth holds over several quarters.

COUNTERPOINT I ACCEPT The rate cuts reduced revenue per transaction; if consumption slows, states, which depend heavily on GST, may face a squeeze.

WAY FORWARD Keep rates stable, widen the base through e-invoicing and data analytics, and create a stable revenue-protection mechanism for states.

MUST-KNOW UPDATE (NOV): October 2026 gross GST ₹2,31,290 crore (+22.9%); imports ₹68,500 crore (+42.2%). GST rationalisation (22 Sept 2025): main slabs of 5% and 18%, plus 40% on sin and luxury goods. GST Council: Art. 279A (101st Amendment, 2016).

FOLLOW-UP CHAIN

P1 *"Should petrol and diesel come under GST?"*
→ In the long run, yes; states need a revenue guarantee first.

P2 *"Is a single GST rate possible?"*
→ Not in an unequal society; a few slabs balance simplicity and fairness.

P3 *"What about compensation cess?"*
→ It has served its purpose; a transparent transition protects states without permanent cesses.

Q13 The India–EU FTA, concluded in January, is to be signed in December. Is it a win for India, given the EU's carbon border tax?

MY VIEW: A strategic win. It opens a market of 27 economies, diversifies away from US uncertainty, and anchors India in global supply chains.

Labour-intensive exports like textiles, leather and gems gain access, and European investment in manufacturing can follow. But the EU's Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism (CBAM) can act as a non-tariff barrier on steel and aluminium, India's key exports to Europe.

COUNTERPOINT I ACCEPT Tariff concessions on autos, wines and machinery can hurt Indian industry, and EU standards on sustainability and labour may raise compliance costs for MSMEs.

WAY FORWARD Use the FTA's transition periods, help MSMEs meet standards, push for recognition of India's Carbon Credit Trading Scheme under CBAM, and finalise the investment protection agreement.

MUST-KNOW Negotiations concluded January 2026; signing planned for December 2026; in force by mid-2027 after European Parliament approval. CBAM definitive phase from 1 January 2026. A separate investment protection agreement is under negotiation.

FOLLOW-UP CHAIN

P1 *"Why did the FTA take 19 years?"*
→ Differences on autos, wines, data, IP and services; changed geopolitics made both sides flexible.

P2 *"Is CBAM protectionism?"*
→ It can work as protection unless it credits carbon prices paid at home; India should negotiate that credit.

P3 *"Which Indian sector gains most?"*
→ Labour-intensive manufacturing: textiles, apparel, leather and footwear.

LUKMAAN IAS • MAINS TEST SERIES

Ethics Test Series (ETS1126) + Ethics YLTS + PYQs Test Series

GS Paper-IV • Online / Offline

Starts 19 Nov 2026

6 tests: 2 sectional + 4 full-length
Recorded discussion videos for Tests 1–4
Model answers, evaluation & mentoring

Soft copies: *Ethics Extended* (facts & examples), *100 Best Case Studies*, one year of ethics current developments
Also: **Ethics Year-Long Test Series** from 20 Nov • **Ethics PYQs Test Series** from 26 Nov

Fee ₹7,500 • Lukmaan ex-students ₹7,000 • Ex-Ethics Foundation ₹6,000 • Validity 3 months

+91 96540 34293
lukmaanias.com

SECTION 04

Ecology & Environment

GS-III: Environment & Disaster Management

CONTEXT CAPSULE Very Severe Cyclonic Storm Arnab crossed the Andhra Pradesh coast in the early hours of 28 October, with winds of 125–135 km/h; four deaths were reported. A Climate Trends study (28 October) found that stubble burning barely influenced Delhi's September–October air in 2024–26. At the pre-COP31 meeting in Fiji, India tied higher ambition to finance ahead of COP31 in Antalya, Türkiye, in November. The IIT Gandhinagar Drought Monitor showed over half of India dry or in drought by mid-September.

IF YOUR DAF SAYS...	PROBABLE QUESTION	YOUR ANGLE
Geography optional	*"Why are Bay of Bengal cyclones stronger than Arabian Sea ones?"*	Warmer waters, landfall on flat coasts and funnel-shaped bay; though Arabian Sea cyclones are rising.
Home state Andhra / Odisha / coastal	*"What did Cyclone Arnab teach your state?"*	Evacuation works; livelihood losses for fishers, aquaculture and power lines remain.
Delhi / Punjab / Haryana	*"Is the farmer the villain of Delhi's air?"*	No. Stubble is a seasonal spike; vehicles, dust, industry and waste burning drive year-round pollution.
Environment / Engineering background	*"How would you clean Delhi's air?"*	Electrify public transport, control construction dust, enforce industrial norms, regional airshed approach.

Q14 Cyclone Arnab, a very severe storm, killed only a handful of people. Has India mastered cyclone management?

MY VIEW: India has mastered saving lives; it has not yet mastered protecting livelihoods.

From about 10,000 deaths in the 1999 Odisha super cyclone to single digits today is a world-class achievement, built on IMD's accurate forecasts, cyclone shelters and early evacuation. But fishers, aquaculture farms, standing crops and power networks still take heavy losses each time.

COUNTERPOINT I ACCEPT Low death tolls depend on strong states like Odisha and Andhra; weaker states and densely built cities remain vulnerable, and climate change is intensifying storms.

WAY FORWARD Parametric insurance that pays fishers and farmers within days, underground power cabling in coastal towns, mangrove belts, and resilient housing standards in high-risk zones.

MUST-KNOW Arnab landfall: Andhra coast, ~2 am, 28 Oct 2026; winds 125–135 km/h, gusts 150 km/h. IMD: Very Severe Cyclonic Storm = 118–165 km/h. National Cyclone Risk Mitigation Project (2011); MISHTI for mangroves (2023).

FOLLOW-UP CHAIN

P1 *"What is the 'Odisha model'?"*
→ Zero-casualty goal, community volunteers, multipurpose shelters and evacuation days in advance.

P2 *"Why does the Bay of Bengal get more cyclones?"*
→ Warmer seas and remnant storms from the Pacific; the Arabian Sea is now catching up.

P3 *"As Collector, the first 24 hours after landfall?"*
→ Search and rescue, restore power and water, open relief camps and begin damage enumeration.

Q15 A new study says stubble burning barely influenced Delhi's air in recent autumns. Have we been blaming farmers wrongly?

MY VIEW: Largely, yes. Stubble causes short spikes, but Delhi's chronic pollution comes from its own sources.

Farm fires in Punjab and Haryana have fallen sharply since 2024, yet Delhi's air has not improved in proportion. Vehicles, road and construction dust, industry, waste burning and household fuels across the NCR are the steady drivers.

COUNTERPOINT I ACCEPT On certain November days, when winds blow from the north-west, stubble can contribute a large share of PM2.5. Ignoring it would be a mistake.

WAY FORWARD Treat the Indo-Gangetic plain as one airshed, electrify buses and last-mile transport, enforce dust and industrial norms, and keep supporting crop-residue management with incentives rather than penalties.

MUST-KNOW Climate Trends report, 28 Oct 2026: stubble 'barely' influenced Delhi's Sept–Oct AQI in 2024–26. Commission for Air Quality Management Act, 2021; GRAP stages. National Clean Air Programme (2019): 40% reduction in particulate matter by 2025–26.

FOLLOW-UP CHAIN

P1 *"Should farmers be fined for burning stubble?"*
→ Penalties alone fail; ex-situ use, machinery and assured buyers for residue work better.

P2 *"Do firecracker bans work?"*
→ They reduce short spikes, but enforcement is weak; awareness and green crackers help more.

P3 *"One step for Delhi this winter?"*
→ Strict dust control at construction sites and roads, which is visible and quick.

Q16 At the pre-COP meeting, India said higher climate ambition must be matched by finance. Is India's position fair, given it is now the third-largest emitter?

MY VIEW: Yes. Ambition without finance and technology is not equity; it shifts the burden onto developing countries.

Developed countries agreed in Baku to only $300 billion a year by 2035, against a need of over $1.3 trillion. India's per-capita emissions are less than half the world average, and it has already met its 2030 non-fossil capacity target five years early.

COUNTERPOINT I ACCEPT Total emissions matter to the climate, not per-capita figures. As a major emitter, India gains credibility by doing more on its own, regardless of finance.

WAY FORWARD Push for quality grant-based finance and adaptation funding, use Article 6 carbon markets and India's Carbon Credit Trading Scheme, and scale domestic green bonds.

MUST-KNOW COP31: Antalya, Türkiye, November 2026; Australia leads negotiations; pre-COP held in Nadi, Fiji. NCQG (COP29, Baku): at least $300 billion a year by 2035; call to scale to $1.3 trillion. Paris Agreement Art. 9.1: developed countries shall provide finance.

FOLLOW-UP CHAIN	
P1	*"Should India accept a coal phase-out date?"* → Not yet; a peaking window with finance and grid storage is credible.
P2	*"Is loss and damage funding working?"* → The fund exists, but money is small; access must be simple for vulnerable countries.
P3	*"What can India offer the world at COP31?"* → Solar Alliance, CDRI and LiFE: practical, scalable models for the Global South.

Q17 Over half of India was dry or in drought by mid-September, and El Niño will last into 2027. Should drought management move from relief to risk management?

MY VIEW: Yes. Drought is predictable; managing it only after crops fail is a policy choice, not a necessity.

Maharashtra alone has declared 265 talukas drought-hit. Each year declarations come late, relief arrives after losses, and groundwater is pumped harder. A risk approach plans crops, water and work before the dry season, not after.

COUNTERPOINT I ACCEPT Relief is still essential for families in distress today; long-term water reform takes years and political courage.

WAY FORWARD Village water budgets, groundwater regulation linked to Atal Bhujal Yojana, drought declarations triggered automatically by data, and shifting procurement towards millets and pulses.

MUST-KNOW IIT Gandhinagar Drought Monitor: ~52.5% of India dry or in drought (16 Sept 2026). Manual for Drought Management (2016, revised 2020); Swaraj Abhiyan v. UoI (2016). WMO: El Niño near-certain to persist through February 2027.

FOLLOW-UP CHAIN	
P1	*"Who should declare drought, Centre or state?"* → States, by objective indicators in the manual; the Centre should fund quickly, not second-guess.
P2	*"Should free electricity for farmers end?"* → Gradually, with direct cash support, because free power drains groundwater.
P3	*"One thing every district can do?"* → A water budget at gram panchayat level before sowing.

SECTION 05

International Relations

GS-II: International Relations

CONTEXT CAPSULE Pakistan resumed airstrikes on Afghanistan from 20 September, blaming India and Kabul for militancy. Polish PM Donald Tusk visited India on 21–24 October; the two sides aim to double trade by 2030 and launch a defence-industry dialogue. India and Canada began the fifth round of CEPA talks on 5 October, followed by a Canadian trade mission. The Strait of Hormuz remained effectively closed: only 2 transits on 25 October, against about 85 a day before the crisis.

IF YOUR DAF SAYS...	PROBABLE QUESTION	YOUR ANGLE
PSIR / History optional	*"Is India's Taliban policy realpolitik or a betrayal of values?"*	Realpolitik with limits: engagement for interests, without recognition or endorsement of their gender policies.
Hobby: languages / travel / Europe	*"Why is Central Europe important to India?"*	Poland as a manufacturing hub, EU voice and defence partner; mention 2024 strategic partnership.
Home state Punjab	*"How should India handle the Canada–Khalistan issue?"*	Separate the diaspora's legitimate interests from extremists; trade and people-to-people ties benefit Punjab.
Merchant navy / Defence background	*"Should the Navy escort tankers through Hormuz?"*	Yes, independently, as under Operation Sankalp since 2019.

Q18 Pakistan is bombing Afghanistan and blaming India for terrorism inside Pakistan. How should India respond?

MY VIEW: Stay out militarily, reject the allegation firmly, and keep building ties with the Afghan people through development and trade.

Pakistan's conflict with the Taliban stems from the TTP, a problem of its own making. India's engagement with Kabul, including the upgrade of its mission to an embassy, is about connectivity, humanitarian aid and preventing Afghan soil from being used against India.

COUNTERPOINT I ACCEPT Closer ties with the Taliban risk legitimising a regime that bars women from education and work, and could draw India into a proxy war narrative.

WAY FORWARD Humanitarian and development aid through credible channels, Chabahar-based trade, quiet counter-terror cooperation, and no formal recognition until the Taliban meets basic rights benchmarks.

MUST-KNOW Pakistan airstrikes from 20 Sept 2026; second round on 24 Sept (10 locations). Taliban FM Muttaqi's India visit, October 2025; India announced upgrade of its Kabul mission to an embassy. Durand Line (1893): not recognised by Afghanistan.

FOLLOW-UP CHAIN

P1 *"Should India recognise the Taliban government?"*
→ Not yet. Engage, but link recognition to inclusive governance and women's rights.

P2 *"Does Pakistan's instability help India?"*
→ No. An unstable nuclear neighbour exports risk; India gains from a stable region.

P3 *"What about Afghan students and patients?"*
→ Restore visas for them; people-to-people ties outlast regimes.

Q19 India and Canada have restored High Commissioners and are negotiating a trade deal. Can trade be insulated from the Khalistan issue?

MY VIEW: Yes, if both sides compartmentalise clearly: cooperate on trade and energy while holding firm red lines on security.

Canada has a large Indian diaspora, abundant uranium and critical minerals, and Indian students and professionals. A uranium contract worth C$2.6 billion and a critical minerals MoU show the economic logic. Freezing ties hurt both, especially Punjab's families.

COUNTERPOINT I ACCEPT Unless Canada acts against violent extremists, every incident can derail talks again, as happened in 2023.

WAY FORWARD Conclude CEPA by the end-2026 target, an NSA-level security workplan with intelligence sharing, and swift legal action against violence rather than public accusations.

MUST-KNOW High Commissioners reinstated August 2025; PM Carney visited India in Feb–Mar 2026. CEPA terms of reference signed March 2026; fifth round from 5 Oct 2026. Cameco–DAE uranium contract: ~C$2.6 billion, deliveries 2027–35.

FOLLOW-UP CHAIN

P1 *"Is free speech in Canada a cover for extremism?"*
→ Free speech protects opinions, not incitement to violence or threats to diplomats.

P2 *"Why does Canada matter to India's energy security?"*
→ Uranium for nuclear power and critical minerals for EVs and batteries.

P3 *"Should India restrict student flows to Canada?"*
→ No; India should help students choose wisely and push for fair visa processing.

Q20 The Polish Prime Minister visited India with about 100 companies. Why does Poland matter to India?

MY VIEW: Poland is a gateway to Central Europe, a fast-growing EU economy and a defence-industrial partner. It helps India diversify in Europe.

The two sides aim to double trade by 2030, start a Defence Industry Dialogue and cooperate on AI, semiconductors and critical minerals. Poland supports India's UN Security Council bid and will join the Coalition for Disaster Resilient Infrastructure.

COUNTERPOINT I ACCEPT Poland is one of the strongest critics of Russia, and closer ties may bring pressure on India's Russia policy.

WAY FORWARD Use the India–EU FTA to anchor Indian firms in Polish manufacturing, co-produce defence equipment, and keep Russia differences out of the bilateral agenda through quiet diplomacy.

MUST-KNOW Strategic Partnership: August 2024 (first Indian PM visit to Poland in 45 years). Modi–Tusk talks, 22 Oct 2026: double trade by 2030; counter-terrorism dialogue. Poland backs India's UNSC permanent membership and 2028–29 non-permanent candidature.

FOLLOW-UP CHAIN

P1	*"What is the 'Good Maharaja' connection?"* → In WWII, the Jam Sahib of Nawanagar sheltered Polish children; it is a lasting goodwill story.
P2	*"How do you reconcile Poland and Russia?"* → India's ties are not zero-sum; each partnership stands on its own interests.
P3	*"Which sector has the most potential?"* → Defence co-production and food processing.

Q21 The Strait of Hormuz is effectively closed again. Should the Indian Navy join a US-led effort to reopen it?

MY VIEW: India should not join a combat coalition, but should escort its own ships independently and coordinate with all navies.

Joining a US-led operation against Iran would make Indian ships and the 90 lakh Indians in the Gulf targets, and damage ties with Iran and Chabahar. Operation Sankalp shows India can protect its own shipping without taking sides.

COUNTERPOINT I ACCEPT	Staying out may look like free-riding on others' efforts, and coalition membership brings intelligence sharing and influence over the outcome.
WAY FORWARD	Strengthen Operation Sankalp, share maritime information through IFC-IOR in Gurugram, diversify crude sources, and push diplomatically for a ceasefire and freedom of navigation.

MUST-KNOW Hormuz: 2 transits on 25 Oct 2026 vs ~85/day pre-crisis (IMF PortWatch). Operation Sankalp: Indian Navy escorts in the Gulf since June 2019. Information Fusion Centre – Indian Ocean Region (Gurugram, 2018).

FOLLOW-UP CHAIN

P1	*"Isn't freedom of navigation everyone's duty?"* → Yes, and India upholds it through its own escorts and diplomacy.
P2	*"What if an Indian ship is attacked?"* → Respond to protect the ship, then pursue diplomatic and legal channels; avoid escalation.
P3	*"How long can India manage high oil prices?"* → Months, with reserves and diversification; the longer-term answer is energy transition.

Q22 India hosted the BRICS summit in September, met Poland and Canada in October, and will sign the EU FTA in December. Is India's foreign policy becoming too trade-focused?

MY VIEW: No. Trade is strategy now: supply chains, technology and markets decide national power as much as militaries do.

After tariff uncertainty with the US and the Hormuz shock, diversifying markets and suppliers is national security. FTAs with the UK, EFTA, New Zealand and the EU reduce dependence on any single partner.

COUNTERPOINT I ACCEPT	Trade deals bring adjustment costs for farmers and MSMEs, and diplomatic attention on trade can crowd out neighbourhood priorities like Afghanistan, Nepal and Bangladesh.
WAY FORWARD	Pair FTAs with domestic competitiveness reforms, and keep a dedicated neighbourhood-first track with connectivity, energy and people-to-people links.

MUST-KNOW India–EFTA TEPA in force October 2025; second India–EFTA Prosperity Summit, 7 Oct 2026. India–New Zealand FTA in force 20 Oct 2026. India–US bilateral trade agreement: first tranche still under negotiation.

FOLLOW-UP CHAIN	
P1	*"Which FTA matters most?"* → The EU deal, for its market size and its standard-setting influence.
P2	*"Are FTAs hurting Indian farmers?"* → Not if sensitive sectors like dairy are protected, as India has consistently done.
P3	*"Should India rejoin RCEP?"* → No; the China import risk remains. Bilateral FTAs are a better route.

LUKMAAN IAS • MAINS TEST SERIES
GS Mains Test Series (GSTS1126)
GS Papers I–IV • Online / Offline
Starts 22 Nov 2026

12 tests: 8 sectional + 4 full-length (FLT)
Papers set on current UPSC trends by subject experts
Evaluation to UPSC standards by faculty
Model answers & PIB compilation (soft copy)
Individual mentoring on request
GS Mains PYQs Test Series from 29 Nov 2026

Fee ₹12,000 • Lukmaan ex-students ₹11,000 • Ex-Foundation students ₹9,000 • Validity 3 months
+91 96540 34293
lukmaanias.com

SECTION 06

Science & Technology

GS-III: Science & Technology, Cyber Security

CONTEXT CAPSULE On 8 October, IT Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw said an AI regulation consultation paper would follow within a month, using a "techno-legal" approach that makes AI firms responsible for user safety and psychological harms, and that indigenous GPUs could handle AI inference within three to four years. On 21 October, SBI disclosed a breach exposing 3,897 customers' personal records, while the DPDP Act's breach-notification duty starts only in May 2027. The 2026 Nobel announcements again raised the question of India's research ecosystem.

IF YOUR DAF SAYS...	PROBABLE QUESTION	YOUR ANGLE
Computer Science / IT graduate	*"What is a GPU and why does India need its own?"*	Parallel processors that train and run AI; supply is concentrated and subject to export controls.
Banking / Finance background	*"Should banks compensate breach victims?"*	Yes where they failed basic security; RBI's zero-liability framework is a model.
Science (PhD / research)	*"Why don't Indian scientists win Nobels?"*	Low R&D; spending, weak university research and brain drain; mention ANRF.
Public Administration optional	*"Should AI decide welfare eligibility?"*	AI can assist, but final decisions need a human officer and an appeal.

Q23 The government plans to make AI companies responsible for users' psychological harms. Is that fair, or will it stifle innovation?

MY VIEW: It is fair. Companies that design products to maximise engagement must also carry a duty of care, especially towards children.

AI chatbots now act as companions and advisers for millions. Cases of harmful advice and emotional dependence show that the risk is real. A techno-legal approach, built into design through safeguards and audits, is better than a sweeping AI law.

COUNTERPOINT I ACCEPT "Psychological harm" is hard to define and prove; vague liability may push startups out and favour big firms that can afford lawyers.

WAY FORWARD Clear harm categories, age-appropriate design rules, mandatory risk assessments for high-reach systems, and a grievance appeal mechanism under the IndiaAI framework.

MUST-KNOW Vaishnaw, 8 Oct 2026: consultation paper within a month; "techno-legal" approach. India AI Governance Guidelines (November 2025): risk-based, light-touch. IndiaAI Mission (2024): ₹10,371.92 crore outlay.

FOLLOW-UP CHAIN

P1 *"Should children be barred from AI chatbots?"*
→ Not barred, but protected: age checks, parental controls and safe defaults.

P2 *"Who decides what is harmful?"*
→ A multi-stakeholder body with experts in psychology, law and technology.

P3 *"Is the EU AI Act better?"*
→ It is thorough but heavy; India needs agility and lower costs for startups.

Q24 The minister says India could have its own GPUs for AI within three to four years. Is chasing compute sovereignty realistic?

MY VIEW: Realistic for inference chips, ambitious for training chips. Even partial self-reliance is worth it, because compute is the new oil.

AI chips are designed by a few firms and made by even fewer foundries, and access can be cut by export controls. Inference chips, which run models already trained, are simpler and have a huge domestic market in public services, telecom and defence.

COUNTERPOINT I ACCEPT Global leaders spend tens of billions a year on chip R&D; India risks spending heavily on chips that are outdated by the time they are ready.

WAY FORWARD Focus on inference and edge chips, use RISC-V open architectures, link design incentives to government procurement, and keep importing frontier GPUs through diversified partners.

MUST-KNOW Initial government GPU tender for 5,000 units; demand estimated at 10,000. India Semiconductor Mission 2.0: $13.5 billion (Sept 2026). Shakti processor (IIT Madras) uses the open RISC-V architecture.

FOLLOW-UP CHAIN

P1 *"Why not rely on the US, a trusted partner?"*
→ Trust is policy, and policy changes; some capacity at home is insurance.

P2	*"What is the difference between training and inference?"* → Training builds the model, using huge compute; inference uses the trained model to answer queries.
P3	*"Is a 'UPI for AI' possible?"* → Yes: shared, interoperable compute and models that startups can plug into.

Q25 SBI disclosed a data breach to stock exchanges, but customers were not directly told. Should banks be legally bound to inform customers immediately?

MY VIEW: Yes. A customer cannot guard against a fraud call she has not been warned about.

The DPDP Act requires notification to every affected person, but that duty starts only in May 2027. Current rules require reporting to regulators, not customers. Meanwhile, leaked phone numbers and loan details are exactly what digital-arrest fraudsters use.

COUNTERPOINT I ACCEPT Notifying before the breach is understood may cause panic or tip off attackers; investigations need some time.

WAY FORWARD The RBI should mandate customer notification within 72 hours, MeitY should bring Section 8(6) into force early, and banks should offer free monitoring and a helpline to those affected.

MUST-KNOW SBI disclosure, 21 Oct 2026: 3,897 customer records with personal data found in a preliminary review. DPDP Act, 2023 Sec. 8(6) and DPDP Rules, 2025 Rule 7: breach notice to Board and individuals, from 13 May 2027; penalty up to ₹250 crore. CERT-In Directions (April 2022): report incidents within 6 hours.

FOLLOW-UP CHAIN

P1	*"Why did the government phase in DPDP over 18 months?"* → To give organisations time to comply; but breach notification could have come first.
P2	*"Who should bear losses from frauds using leaked data?"* → Where the bank's security failed, the bank should share the loss.
P3	*"As a district officer, how would you warn citizens?"* → SMS alerts, local media and bank-branch notices: 'Banks never ask for OTPs or video-call KYC.'

Q26 Every October the Nobel prizes are announced, and India-based science rarely features. Why, and what should change?

MY VIEW: India has talent but not the ecosystem. Low research spending and weak university research drive our best minds abroad.

India spends about 0.64% of GDP on R&D;, against over 2% in China and over 3% in the US. Private industry contributes little. The last Nobel for science done in India was C.V. Raman's in 1930; several Indian-origin laureates did their work abroad.

COUNTERPOINT I ACCEPT Nobel prizes reward decades-old work and are a narrow measure; India's achievements in space, vaccines and digital public goods matter more for development.

WAY FORWARD Fund curiosity-driven research through the ANRF, attract private R&D; with the ₹1 lakh crore RDI scheme, give universities autonomy, and create return pathways for Indian scientists abroad.

MUST-KNOW Gross R&D; spending ≈ 0.64% of GDP. Anusandhan National Research Foundation Act, 2023. Research, Development and Innovation (RDI) Scheme: ₹1 lakh crore corpus (approved July 2025).

FOLLOW-UP CHAIN	
P1	*"Is brain drain bad for India?"* → It becomes 'brain gain' only if we create reasons and routes to return.
P2	*"Should research funding favour applied science?"* → Both are needed; basic research creates tomorrow's applied breakthroughs.
P3	*"One reform for universities?"* → Separate teaching and research tracks with research grants tied to output, not seniority.

SECTION 07

Rapid-fire Board Traps

One or two sentences, then stop

Trap question	Safe, honest line
"Was the Delhi lockdown an assault on democracy?"	It was disproportionate, as the Supreme Court noted; but the state's duty to keep order is also real.
"Is the Election Commission's appointment law unconstitutional?"	That is for the Constitution Bench; I believe neutrality must be built into the design.
"Is the CJI above criticism?"	No one is; criticism should be on reasoning, not motives.
"Should Manipur get an NRC?"	Migration fears are real, but the Census should not wait; verification can run separately.
"Is the rupee's fall a failure of government?"	Largely an oil and global-capital shock; policy can smooth it, not stop it.
"Are farmers responsible for Delhi's pollution?"	Partly on some days; Delhi's own sources matter more over the year.
"Should India talk to the Taliban?"	Engage for interests and the Afghan people; no recognition without basic rights.
"Is India too close to the West now?"	India is close to its interests; it engages the West, Russia and the Global South together.
"Should AI be regulated like medicines?"	High-risk uses, yes; everyday tools need lighter, proportionate rules.
"Why should taxpayers fund basic research?"	Because today's basic research is tomorrow's industry and security.

Three Closing Tips

- If asked "What would you do as DM / SP / Collector?", always cover prevention, response and accountability.
- If a board member strongly disagrees, acknowledge the point and restate yours once; do not repeat it a third time.
- Never criticise a named individual or party. Critique policies and institutions, with a solution.

LUKMAAN IAS • UPCOMING PROGRAMMES	STARTS
Public Admin. Crash Course	**16 Nov 2026**
Ethics Test Series (ETS1126)	**19 Nov 2026**
Essay & Ethics Year-Long Test Series	**20 Nov 2026**
Essay Test Series (EST1126)	**20 Nov 2026**
Public Admin. Test Series & YLTS	**21 Nov 2026**
GS Mains Test Series (GSTS1126)	**22 Nov 2026**
PYQs Test Series: Ethics / Essay / PA / GS	**26–29 Nov 2026**
AIPMT-II (Prelims Mock)	**29 Nov 2026**
GS Paper-II Foundation Batch	**14 Dec 2026**

Scan to enrol
+91 96540 34293
enquiries@lukmaanias.com
60/17, 2nd Floor, Old Rajinder Nagar,
New Delhi – 110060

SECTION 08

Practice Lab

Ten unanswered questions • Self-evaluation rubric

How to practise: answer each question aloud in 90 seconds, recording yourself. Then ask a friend to play the board and press you with two follow-ups. Score yourself on the rubric below; anything under 11 out of 15 needs another attempt.

#	Question	Score /15
1.	Should every city have a legally designated protest site with guaranteed access?	
2.	Should the Chief Justice be part of the panel that selects Election Commissioners?	
3.	Should 'scandalising the court' be dropped as a ground of contempt?	
4.	Should preventive detention orders be reviewed by a sitting High Court judge?	
5.	Should India permanently ban onion exports to keep prices stable?	
6.	Should petrol and diesel be brought under GST now?	
7.	Your coastal district faces a cyclone in 72 hours. What is your action plan?	
8.	Should India accept a fixed coal phase-out date in return for climate finance?	
9.	Should India recognise the Taliban government?	
10.	Should banks be fined if they fail to inform customers of a data breach within 72 hours?	

Self-Evaluation Rubric

Criterion	1 – Needs work	2 – Adequate	3 – Board-ready
Clarity of view	Position unclear or buried	Position stated but hedged	Clear view in first sentence
Reasoning & facts	No fact or wrong fact	One relevant fact	Two reasons + one precise fact
Balance	One-sided	Mentions other side vaguely	Concedes strongest counterpoint honestly
Way forward	None	Generic ("awareness, coordination")	Specific, administrative, feasible
Composure under follow-up	Defensive or changes stand	Holds stand but repeats	Accepts valid point, holds core calmly